

Introduction

Becoming an advocate for children with autism spectrum disorder (ASD) is crucial for those needing counseling services but are unable to advocate for themselves. Children with ASD often have barriers that enable them to advocate for their needs properly. These challenges often involve communication, social interactions and behaviors caused by not being able to express themselves. By researching counseling for children with autism, we can acknowledge ways to support and provide resources that will help them have a better lifestyle in their future. Three learning objectives on this advocacy presentation are 1) Acknowledging challenges that children with ASD face, 2) Identify how counseling can impact children, 3) Ways to advocate.

Facts and Statistics

- Boys are 4 times more likely than girls to develop ASD (CDC, 2013)
- ASD is reported to occur in all racial, ethnic, and socioeconomic groups. (CDC, 2013)
- “Autism spectrum disorder (ASD) is a neurodevelopmental disorder that affects 1 in 59 children in the United States.” (Smith et. al, 2020, p. 36)
- Parents with less than a high school education are less likely to enroll their children in ASD therapy. (Smith et. al, 2020, p. 38)
- Autism prevalence is lower among white children than other racial and ethnic groups. (Smith et. al, 2020, p. 36)
- “Early treatment for ASD is important because proper care and services can reduce individuals’ difficulties while helping them learn new skills and build on their strengths.” (U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, 2022)
- Autism is known as a “spectrum” disorder because there is wide variation in the type and severity of symptoms people experience. (U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, 2022)

Ways counselors can help

- Engage in local awareness campaigns.
- Help clients develop self-advocacy skills.
- Provide workshops at schools.
- Provide resources to families.

Web resources

<https://autisticadvocacy.org/about-asan/about-autism/>

<https://www.autismspeaks.org/tool-kit/100-day-kit-young-children>

<https://autismnavigator.com/webinars/>

APA references

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (n.d.). *Data and statistics on autism spectrum disorder*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. <https://www.cdc.gov/autism/data-research/index.html>

Smith KA, Gehricke Jean-G, Iadarola S, et al. Disparities in Service Use Among Children With Autism: A Systematic Review. *Pediatrics*. 2020

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. (2022). *Autism spectrum disorder*. National Institute of Mental Health. <https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/autism-spectrum-disorder>